



South China Karst

One of the world's largest and finest examples of a karst landscape, featuring a variety of dramatic rock formations

Covering an area of about 190,000 square miles (500,000 square km), mostly within the provinces of Guizhou, Guangxi, Yunnan, and Chongqing, South China karst is the world's largest karst terrain—a landscape characterized by an array of weathered limestone formations. The diversity, number, and spectacular nature of the geological features make South China karst the greatest example of a humid tropical and subtropical karst landscape on Earth. Since 2007 it has been a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Caves, towers, and pinnacles

South China karst is perhaps best known for its isolated stone towers, often rising more than 330 ft (100 m) from a broad mosaic of farmland, and its clusters of cone-shaped hills covered in lush, cloud-draped

▷ TRAINED TO FISH

Cormorants are used in a traditional method of fishing on the rivers that cross South China karst. The great cormorant is a favored species.



forests (see pp.248–49). In fact, the region is regarded by geologists as being home to the defining examples of formations such as tower karst (fenglin), cone karst (fengcong), and pinnacle karst (shilin), which creates dense stone forests (see below). It also features many giant sinkholes (or dolines), gorges, natural bridges, and table mountains. Beneath the ground there are extensive cave systems containing subterranean rivers and vast caverns rich in stalactites, stalagmites, and other cave deposits.

Mature landscape

The limestone rock in which South China karst is formed was laid down on the ocean floor over a long period before being uplifted. This produced an exceptionally thick, strong, and horizontal bedrock from which the massive and relatively stable landforms have been carved. Although the region's warm and wet climate has enabled the chemical weathering of the limestone to occur at a relatively rapid rate (see pp.248–49), it has been estimated that the fengcong and fenglin karsts of Guizhou and Guangxi have been evolving over a period of 10–20 million years. The result is what is often described as the ultimate mature karst landscape.



One of the region's **vast caves** houses a village of more than **100 people**

▷ STONE FOREST

These tightly bundled limestone pinnacles forming stone forests near the village of Shilin, in Yunnan Province, are considered classic examples of what has become known as shilin karst.

